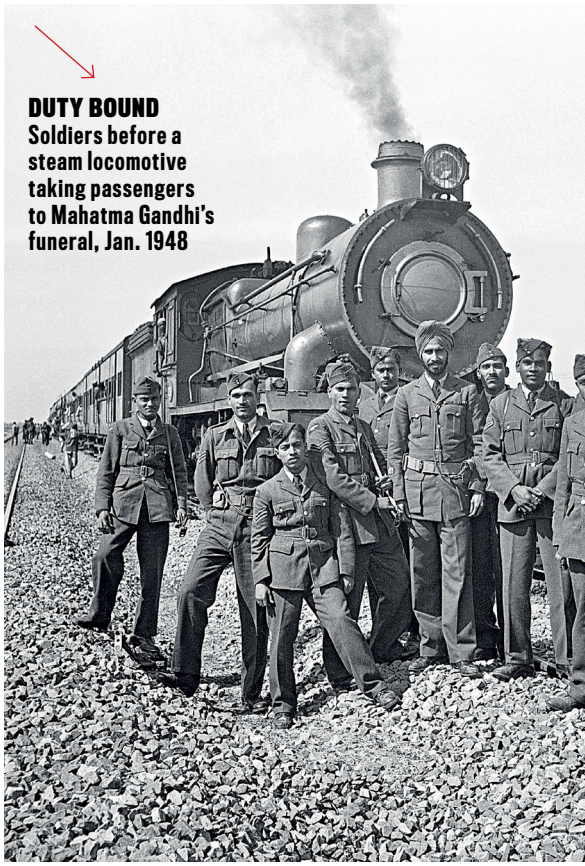
ON THE FAST TRACK

Despite its **poor financial health**, Indian Railways aims to match global standards of rail journey in the next 25 years

By Anilesh S. Mahajan



DUTY BOUND Soldiers before a steam locomotive taking passengers to Mahatma Gandhi's funeral, Jan. 1948



At the time of Independence and the subsequent partition of the country, the Indian Railways (IR) underwent a major surgery. Apart from the division of assets, tracks, rolling stocks and transfers of the workforce, the working of five zones—Eastern Punjab, East Indian, Oudh &Tirhut, Indian portion of Bengal Assam Railways—was severely impacted due to the country's division.

Between 1950 and 1954, IR managed to reorganise itself—new divisions were carved out and new tie-ups were made for manufacturing—and started to upgrade its infrastructure.

Today, India has the world's fourth-largest rail network—only after the US, China and Europe. In the past few years, the country has made efforts to modernise the railways, but at the core, the problem lies in fare and tariff charges. As per IR, the cost of passenger fares and services comes to around Rs 1.16 per km, but the Railways charges only 48 paise per km. This makes the fares the

MILESTONES

1947
Post-Partition, India gets a route network of **49,523 km** (broad gauge and metre gauge) and 5,370 km of narrow gauge. With **8,120 steam locomotives,** besides 72 electric and 17 diesel-fuelled ones, Indian Railways (IR) transports 3.52 million passengers and 0.2 million tonnes of freight every day

1951-52
All agencies and entities governing railways are restructured into regional zones. Two years later, the **Railway Board** is constituted to take all decisions related to policy, technology and operations

1955
First fully AC train starts operations between Howrah and Delhi, followed by another between Delhi and Bombay Central. Later, a buffet-cum-cinema car is added to Janata Express

1956
With the help of French major SNCF, the **Railway Electrification Project** is started. Till then only some suburban trains, principally in Mumbai, were electrified